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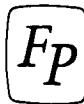
World Politics

An Introduction

James N. Rosenau

Kenneth W. Thompson

Gavin Boyd



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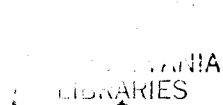
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17.

Mass Communication and Diplomacy

W. Phillips Davison

In the making and execution of foreign policy, national governments communicate with other governments, with publics in their own nations, and with publics in other countries. All these communication flows are two-way. Thus there are five primary categories of information and influence with which we are concerned. These are shown diagrammatically in Figure 17-1 on the following page.

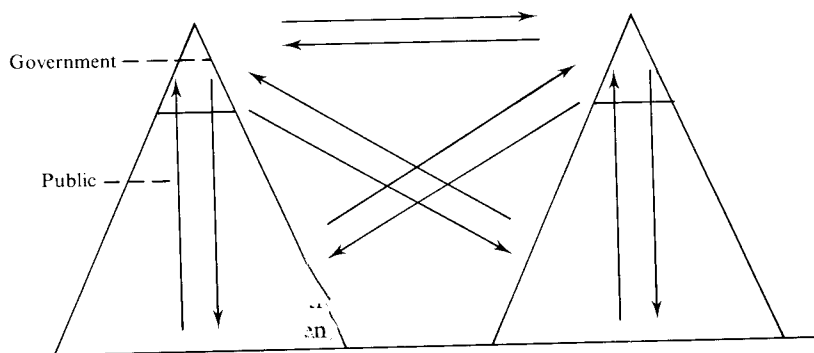
Communication among governments is often referred to as diplomacy, although the information that one government obtains about another nation through either open or secret channels is sometimes known as "intelligence." Communications from a government to its own population may be called "public information," while the flow of messages from the population to the government can be thought of as "public opinion."¹ Information directed by a government to the population of another nation is usually considered "propaganda." And when people attempt to influence the government of another country through petitions or other messages sent to that government, we may speak of "international public opinion." The flow of information between publics in different countries, with which we are not concerned here and which is therefore not represented in Figure 17-1, may be called "cultural relations."

All the above designations are labels of convenience, and may occasionally be misleading. Governments can exchange messages that have little to do with diplomacy. A government can propagandize its own people or can seek to inform foreign publics. Some communications from domestic publics to their governments are difficult to envisage as public opinion. Nevertheless, these labels may be useful in differentiating among the various flows of political communication.

Information passes through many kinds of channels. Some messages are transmitted face to

¹ This definition of public opinion is taken from Hans Speier, *Social Order and the Risks of War* (New York: George W. Stewart, 1952), p. 323: "Let us understand by public opinion . . . opinions on matters of concern to the nation freely and publicly expressed by men outside the government who claim a right that their opinions should influence or determine the actions, personnel, or structure of their government."

I am, in addition, indebted to Dr. Speier's unpublished work for the conception of international communication on which Figure 17-1 is based.

Figure 17-1. The Flow of Political Communications

face, or point to point; others flow through organizational structures—for example, political parties, labor unions, churches, or professional associations; still others are communicated by planned events, and may be called “propaganda of the deed”—as in the case of naval demonstrations or ceremonial gifts. A large proportion of political communications, however, are transmitted through mass media channels, including wire services, newspapers, radio, and television. It is the role of the mass media in international relations and the ways they interact with other channels with which we will be primarily concerned.

Many factors affect these information flows and their effects. Among them are the political systems in the countries concerned, the number and power of those members of the public who are interested in foreign affairs, the nature of the issues under discussion, and the kinds of communication systems that are available. Some governments are more sensitive to public opinion than others; foreign policy issues that immediately affect the lives of many people receive more public attention than those that do not; mass media may be highly developed or rudimentary; political parties may be efficient channels for the transmission of messages to and from governments or may consist of loosely organized, shifting coalitions.

The following discussion will apply mainly to conditions in the United States and other industrialized democracies, although occasional reference will be made to varying conditions in other types of societies.

ATTENTION TO THE MASS MEDIA BY DIPLOMATS

The importance that foreign policy personnel attach to the mass media is attested by the time and attention they give them.² Two patterns of attention can be identified. Those diplomats who are of high rank and are located in foreign ministries tend to read several newspapers or magazines that can be classified as belonging to the “elite” international press. In Western Europe this group of publications includes the *Times* of London, *Le Monde* of Paris, the *Neue Zürcher Zeitung*, the *Frankfurter Allgemeine Zeitung*, the *International Herald Tribune*, *The Economist*, and the European editions of *Newsweek* and *Time*. Other elite publications that are frequently read by diplomats, depending on their location and special interests, include *The Observer*, the *Guardian*, and the *Financial Times*, all published in England, Stockholm’s *Dagens Nyheter*, and Munich’s *Süddeutsche Zeitung*. How many of these publications are read regularly by a diplomat differs from case to case, but it is rare to encounter a foreign office official in any Western European country (except Italy, Portugal, and Spain, where a somewhat different set of elite publications is involved) who is not familiar with the content of at least three of them. Some read as many as six.

High-ranking personnel of the Department of State in Washington and diplomats stationed at

² W. Phillips Davison, “News Media and International Negotiation,” *Public Opinion Quarterly*, vol. 38, no. 2 (Summer 1974), pp. 174-191.

the United Nations in New York tend to rely heavily on the *New York Times*, the *Washington Post*, and the *Wall Street Journal*. In addition, they are likely to see some of the elite papers of Europe, Japan, the Soviet Union, or other areas with which they are particularly concerned.

The roster of the elite press does not begin to exhaust the list of mass media to which diplomats at foreign ministries devote attention. When they arrive at their offices, they are likely to be confronted with one or more press summaries prepared by some agency of their government. These summaries may digest—and quote from—a wide range of the domestic press, the foreign press, and transcriptions of radio and television broadcasts. Specialized summaries covering media dealing with economic, fiscal, or other matters may also be prepared. The diplomat usually does not have time to read all these press digests completely, but any items that specially concern him will probably have been marked by a subordinate. Or he may locate items of particular interest by glancing at an index. If he is able to leave his office early enough, he may take in the evening “prestige” news show on television, or he may see it on a receiver in the office, although professional and social engagements frequently make it impossible for him to watch.

Nearly all foreign ministries also have one or more wire service tickers installed. The incoming print-outs are inspected at frequent intervals, and items are distributed to those officials who are concerned with them. The first word of new developments on the international scene is usually brought to foreign office officials in this manner.

The attention of diplomats stationed outside their own country tends to follow a somewhat different pattern. They may read one or more of the great international newspapers or magazines, but they are likely to spend even more time monitoring the media of the host country. Either they or their subordinates will read newspapers and magazines representing all major shades of opinion and will also try to keep up with views expressed on the local radio and television. The embassy may prepare a summary or digest of the local press, and make it available to all diplomatic personnel, or each section of the

embassy may monitor those media that are of particular interest to it. In addition, the embassy is likely to receive—sometimes by radio—a digest of the press back home. This includes summaries of major stories and commentaries, whether published or broadcast, from media in the capital. And depending on the location of the embassy, whether it is in a major news center or is in a more remote part of the world, diplomats will tune in the radio to obtain news one or more times a day. The British Broadcasting Corporation's morning news program seems to be the most popular source of information for those diplomats who rely on radio.

Also, many diplomats, stationed either in their own countries or abroad, cultivate the acquaintance of journalists and meet with them frequently. The journalist provides a useful supplementary source of information. He may know something that has not yet been published or broadcast, or he may be able to provide additional details about a major story of the day.

THE PRESS AS AN AUXILIARY TO DIPLOMATIC CHANNELS

Most official communications from one government to another are conveyed by diplomatic notes or by personal conversations between foreign policy personnel of different states, but the mass media may sometimes serve as a supplement, or even as an alternative, to diplomatic channels of communication. Not infrequently, a statesman or diplomat will make a statement, or arrange for a leak, primarily in order to convey a message to his opposite number in another country. Mass media channels played an important role prior to the start of formal negotiations ending the Berlin blockade of 1948–1949. Stalin made a statement in reply to a question submitted to him by the International News Service in which he implied that the Soviet Union would be willing to resume negotiations on ending the blockade. This statement was noted by Dean Acheson, then United States Secretary of State, who signaled back via a news conference that the United States was also interested in negotiating, but would like to use a

more private channel.³ Formal talks started shortly thereafter. Other examples of the use of the mass media to convey diplomatic messages can be found in connection with the Quemoy crisis of 1958 and the negotiations concerning Laos in 1961. The practice of encoding information in a public communication which, it is hoped, will be noted and decoded by another government is sometimes referred to as "signaling," and is a common diplomatic practice.⁴

Somewhat less common, although many cases of it can be observed, is the practice of entrusting diplomatic messages to individual newsmen, with either the explicit or implicit request that these be conveyed to another government. At the height of the Cuban missile crisis, a senior official of the Soviet Embassy in Washington asked the State Department correspondent of the American Broadcasting Company if he would convey a message to "high-level friends in the State Department." This message detailed conditions under which the Soviets would remove offensive missiles from Cuba. The State Department then sent word back via the same correspondent that it would be interested in discussing the Soviet proposal further.⁵ Similarly, several British and West German newsmen have mentioned to the author that they had been asked to convey diplomatic messages at one time or another. Some declined to do this, on the grounds that it would be inconsistent with their journalistic role. But even correspondents who are unwilling to transmit diplomatic messages on a person-to-person basis seem to be willing to include them in the dispatches they write for publication.

Governments are constantly in *indirect* communication with each other, in that each attempts to learn as much as possible about the characteristics, intentions, actions, strengths, and weaknesses of other governments. Some of this infor-

mation comes through secret intelligence channels, some from the reports of diplomats stationed abroad, and some is derived directly from press reports that come to the attention of the government's foreign office.

Much secret intelligence comes from the mass media. Admiral Zacharias, who headed American Naval Intelligence during World War II, has observed that 90 percent of intelligence is based on a careful analysis of the public press. This was confirmed by Allan Dulles, who for many years was Director of the Central Intelligence Agency. He mentioned newspapers, books, and magazines as primary intelligence sources.⁶

Diplomatic reporting, too, is heavily dependent on the mass media. A peppery British journalist has characterized much diplomatic reporting as a "nineteenth century charade." In theory, he writes, diplomats "are supposed to get their information from dinnertable badinage with the foreign minister's wife," but in practice "diplomats abroad use the newspapers and broadcasting stations of the capital as a principal source."⁷ He goes on to point out that journalists can talk with people—for instance, members of the political opposition—who are much less accessible to diplomats. Journalists can also move about without attracting as much attention as an official would. In some countries, a diplomat who sought to keep in touch with opponents of the government in power would probably be accused of interfering in domestic politics, while the journalist can make such contacts as a matter of routine.

It would be an exaggeration to picture the diplomat as totally dependent on the press, but it is true that a large proportion of diplomatic reporting consists of analyses based on the work of journalists. Indeed, a United States Foreign Service officer has noted there is a kind of competition between reports emanating from embassies and those flowing through public channels.⁸ The ambassador and his staff are faced with

³ Dean Acheson, *Present at the Creation: My Years in the State Department* (New York: New American Library, 1970), pp. 353–56.

⁴ Numerous examples of the use of the mass media for "signaling" in international relations are given in Robert Jervis, *The Logic of Images in International Relations* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1970).

⁵ Roger Hilsman, *To Move a Nation* (Garden City, N.Y.: Doubleday, 1967), pp. 217–18; Elie Abel, *The Missile Crisis* (New York: Bantam, 1966), pp. 155–158.

⁶ Allan Dulles, "The Craft of Intelligence," *Harper's*, April 1963.

⁷ John Whale, *Journalism and Government* (Columbia: University of South Carolina Press, 1972), p. 29.

⁸ Glen H. Fisher, *Public Diplomacy and the Behavioral Sciences* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1972), p. 4.

the question of what they can tell their own government that has not already been disclosed by wire services or one of the mass media. They can report material gathered in the course of their own face-to-face conversations with members of the host government and other nationals of the host country, and they can forward statistics and information of a technical nature that would not be of interest to journalists. But beyond this their contribution consists largely of culling information from the mass media, putting this into perspective, and relating it to current policy questions.

In countries where the press is government-controlled, it is carefully studied to gain additional information about official attitudes. George Kennan, former United States Ambassador to Moscow, relates that he had little success in hearing more than the familiar party line when he visited the Soviet Foreign Office. Officials there were polite but reserved, and "one did not normally attempt to discuss political questions with them." They apparently believed that their offices were "bugged" and were cautious about expressing themselves. Kennan writes, "We were left, therefore, to derive our impressions of Soviet attitudes from the press and other public media of official expression."⁹

Diplomatic reporting requires not only close attention to the mass media but also the ability to interpret their content. The meaning of a news story can be assessed more accurately if one knows as much as possible about the correspondent writing it, the political tendencies of the medium in which it is carried, the way in which news is handled in this medium, and the audience for which it is intended. How careful is the correspondent and how good are his sources? Are his editors likely to revise his copy, and along what lines? Has the material been shaped so as to appeal to a particular audience? The answers to questions such as these make it possible to do a better job of placing reported information in context. The press counselor at a Washington embassy, for instance, is likely to be asked by his government whether the opinion of such and such

a commentator should be taken seriously. In other words, "he has to judge whether so-and-so currently cuts ice in the White House."¹⁰

Of course a country does not necessarily have to maintain an embassy in the capital of another nation in order to obtain access to that nation's press. Newspapers can be obtained through third countries or even by direct subscription. Radio (and sometimes television) can be monitored from outside a country's borders. What amounts to diplomatic reporting can take place through secret intelligence channels. In such cases the task of analysis may be undertaken by political specialists in the capital, and may be incorporated directly into the policy-making process at the foreign ministry. Even though North Vietnam and the United States did not maintain diplomatic relations during the Vietnamese War, both countries were obviously making careful studies of each other's press. An American diplomat who took part in the early stages of negotiations with the North Vietnamese in Paris reported that the Vietnamese negotiators were well informed as to the contents of the American press. One of them even quoted *I. F. Stone's Weekly* in the course of the negotiations.

Information gained from radio broadcasts is less likely to be reported through traditional diplomatic channels than is information from newspapers and other publications. Most major powers maintain monitoring facilities, either within their own borders or on the territory of a friendly state. There short-wave and sometimes medium-wave broadcasts from other countries are recorded and then transcribed and translated. The resulting reports, sometimes giving complete texts and sometimes summaries of transmissions regarded as important, often receive wide circulation among officials of the government doing the monitoring. These monitoring reports can be considered an integral part of diplomatic reporting, even though they may not be prepared by diplomats at all. Like telegrams or other messages received from embassies, they provide information about events and attitudes in other countries, and

⁹ George F. Kennan, *Memoirs 1950-1963* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1972), p. 122.

¹⁰ A. L. Valencia (Press Counselor at the Philippine Embassy), "How It's Done," in John Lee (ed.), *The Diplomatic Persuaders* (New York: Wiley, 1968), p. 47.

are incorporated into the process of foreign policy making.

Some of the monitoring reports prepared by the Foreign Broadcast Information Service of the United States government are public documents and are available to scholars and the press. Indeed, they constitute a major source of information for Washington journalists who cover international affairs. These journalists, when they choose to make use of materials from a Foreign Broadcast Information Service document, may provide a link in the chain of communication between two governments. Thus Moscow may beam a short-wave broadcast to North America, which is recorded and transcribed. Journalists may then prepare stories based on the monitoring report. These stories are picked up by the Soviet Embassy in Washington, the Soviet news service Tass, or some other agency and reported back to Moscow. The Soviet government then knows that this particular message was received in Washington and may get some American reactions to it.

Journalists also play an involuntary role in diplomatic reporting through their news-gathering activities. Most foreign correspondents make it a practice to visit informally with embassy or foreign office officials in the capital that they cover. In the course of these visits a certain amount of information swapping is likely to take place. The journalist intimates that he has tidbits that might be of interest to the official and suggests that he would like a newsworthy item in return. Or the diplomat may initiate the exchange. In any case, if both are agreeable, the journalist has an item to use in his next story, and the diplomat incorporates some new information in a report to his foreign office or in a memorandum for the foreign ministry files.

Thus it is only a slight exaggeration to say that the mass media are the eyes and ears of diplomacy. Diplomatic reporting can take place without them, and sometimes does, but it is much more difficult. Indeed, a United States Foreign Service officer has whimsically suggested that the easiest way to improve diplomatic reporting would be to improve the world press.¹¹

¹¹ Thomas A. Donovan, "Political Reporting Trends," *Foreign Service Journal*, November 1963.

PUBLIC INFORMATION

One of the principles of democracy is that the citizens ought to know what their government is doing. This applies to foreign as well as domestic affairs. A constant stream of messages about foreign policy—informative, persuasive, or both—emanates from the executive and is directed to various sectors of the population.

In totalitarian states, where the rulers do not require the formal consent of the governed, the stream of messages is likely to be even larger. As one authority has noted, "the most salient characteristic of totalitarianism is the massive amount of communication which flows from the party elite and their agents to the masses."¹² Most of these messages concern domestic matters, but a substantial proportion of them appear designed to mobilize support for foreign policies. Since the party and state control the major channels of communication, the task of reaching the masses is relatively simple. Furthermore, the masses can be compelled to pay attention.¹³

Most democracies, by contrast, have to rely on information media that are not government-controlled, even though some of them may be publicly owned. Great emphasis is therefore placed on preparing press releases, holding press conferences, organizing news-making events, and talking informally with reporters. In the United States, the News Division of the State Department is the office most centrally concerned with the dissemination of information about foreign policy, but a large amount of information on the country's international relations also comes from the White House, the Department of Commerce, the Treasury, and especially the Department of Defense. The Defense Department has been ac-

¹² Richard R. Fagen, *Politics and Communication* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1966, p. 33).

¹³ In 1951, when the Chinese Ministry of Cultural Affairs released a film entitled "Resist America, Aid Korea," committees were formed in every major city to ensure that the largest possible number of people saw the film. In Canton alone, a few days before the motion picture was to be shown, the official newspaper reported that an estimated audience of 525,000 had already been mobilized. See Frederick T. C. Yu, "Communications and Politics in Communist China," in Lucian W. Pye (ed.), *Communications and Political Development* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1963), pp. 282-283.

cused by unfriendly critics of maintaining a swollen public relations establishment and of going beyond the bounds of public information, especially by organizing news-making events.¹⁴

The most effective way for a government in a democracy to reach the public is for the chief executive to appear on television or, if television does not exist, to address the population by radio. A president or prime minister can ordinarily command a portion of prime broadcasting time, and can reach a large proportion of the households in his or her country. Indeed, television has been called "the presidential medium," and some observers believe that in the United States it has upset the constitutional balance of power, giving the executive primacy over Congress and the judiciary.¹⁵

There are, however, limitations on television as a medium through which a government can disseminate information about foreign affairs. The chief executive can appear only occasionally and can speak on only a narrow range of subjects; otherwise, his appearances would cease to be newsworthy events and he would lose his audience. And there are few other official spokesmen who are considered newsworthy enough to be given more than a few seconds on evening news shows. To convey more than incidental information on most questions about foreign policy, governments must rely primarily on the print media, and secondarily on speeches by officials and meetings with members of the public who are particularly interested.

In spite of efforts by governments to encourage knowledge about foreign affairs, for whatever purpose, most populations remain relatively ignorant of international issues. Public opinion polls have found that nearly all adults in industrialized nations are aware of spectacular events and the names of major world figures; but when it comes to the substance of important international agreements or the content of specific foreign policies, between a half and two-thirds are likely to profess complete ignorance. Thus, shortly after an Amer-

ican spy plane had been shot down over the Soviet Union, more than nine out of ten Americans were aware of this, but when President Kennedy announced a plan to encourage trade by lowering tariffs, more than half of a national sample said they had heard nothing about it. A mass circulation British daily urged for over a year that Britain join the European Common Market, but several months after French President de Gaulle blocked the British entry, a poll of the paper's readers found that 54 percent did not know what the Common Market was.¹⁶

It is difficult to estimate the proportion of any population that pays attention to information about foreign policies, partly because degrees of attention can vary so widely and partly because attention varies from issue to issue. Most Americans were fairly well informed about at least some aspects of the war in Vietnam, but few followed the progress of conferences on disarmament. Furthermore, interest varies according to the population group of which one is speaking. Americans of Irish descent are likely to be acquainted with American policies toward Ireland; those with economic interests in the Far East are likely to know about our relations with Japan; and so on. As a very rough approximation, it might be said that about 10 percent of adult Americans are reasonably knowledgeable about foreign affairs. These are the people that Gabriel Almond has characterized as the "attentive public," although without giving an estimate of their numbers.¹⁷ In general, they are readers of the quality newspapers and the national news magazines.

Governments try to reach as broad an audience as possible with information and sometimes propaganda about foreign affairs, but in practice they are able to interest only a relatively small propor-

¹⁴ J. William Fulbright, *The Pentagon Propaganda Machine* (New York: Liveright, 1970).

¹⁵ Newton H. Minow et al., *Presidential Television* (New York: Basic Books, 1973).

¹⁶ Sir Douglas Busk, *The Craft of Diplomacy* (New York: Praeger, 1967), p. 87. Convenient though somewhat dated studies of ignorance about foreign policy questions in the United States and West Germany can be found in John P. Robinson, *Public Information about World Affairs* (Ann Arbor: Survey Research Center of the University of Michigan, 1967); and Elisabeth Noelle and Erich Peter Neumann (eds.), *The Germans: Public Opinion Polls 1947-1966* (Allensbach, Germany: Verlag für Demoskopie, 1967).

¹⁷ Gabriel A. Almond, *The American People and Foreign Policy* (New York: Harcourt, Brace, 1950).

tion of the population in any given issue. The news media are deluged with official press releases, but few of these are used by newspapers, radio, or television. And many of the releases that are used receive little attention. In general, it is difficult to interest large publics in issues that are highly technical or complex or that concern far-away places and people. Also, most countries seem to experience fluctuations in public attention to international affairs. During an isolationist phase the numbers of those interested in foreign policy tends to contract, and more headlines deal with domestic issues.

Most governments, therefore, place special emphasis on communications to groups that are likely to have a sustained interest in foreign policy questions or a major interest in one or another particular issue. The United States State Department, for example, arranges briefings for citizen groups composed of those who are particularly concerned with international affairs, such as members of the Foreign Policy Association. State Department officials frequently address university audiences and meet with business, labor, or religious leaders. Government representatives, who sometimes function much like lobbyists, attend conventions organized by veterans, farmers, ethnics, and other interest groups. Documents on foreign policy, including texts of speeches and important documents, are sent to mailing lists of those who have indicated an interest in receiving them. Journalists who regularly write on foreign policy issues, especially for the "elite" press, are treated with respect and have good access to high officials in the State Department and the White House.¹⁸

There are several reasons why a government may seek to inform or persuade its citizens with respect to foreign policy issues. In an authoritarian or totalitarian state the power of the government is increased if the public can be mobilized to back its policies: to work harder in order to surpass another country in steel production, to demonstrate in favor of a government policy or against the policy of another nation, to report any suspicious activities that might indicate the

presence of enemy agents. More generally, a totalitarian government seeks to buttress its position by inducing all citizens to show overt support for all its policies, domestic as well as foreign. To this end, a constant stream of communications from government to the public is maintained, even though the government is under little pressure to reveal information about all issues or about all aspects of a given issue.¹⁹

In democracies, officials usually accept at least in principle that the citizenry should be informed about what the government is doing. Some public information about foreign affairs is in the nature of an accounting to the public, or to their representatives in the legislature. More commonly, publicity is disseminated for the purpose of convincing those interested in foreign affairs that the policies of the government are the correct ones, to promote acceptance of what is being done, and to forestall pressures for changes. If there is widespread apathy about an issue, this has the effect of freeing the officials concerned to do what they think is best.²⁰ If the press raises questions or objections, then it may become necessary or advisable to make an explanatory statement, issue a press release, or confer with influential citizens. Foreign policy communications from a government to the public in a democracy result from complex mixed motivations on the part of officials: the feeling that the citizens should be kept informed, the desire for public support, the wish to be left alone, and the hope of avoiding adverse pressures that may result if information is *not* made available.

DOMESTIC OPINION

In addition to informing the citizens, the government of a democracy should also listen to them. According to democratic theory, governments rule with the consent of the governed. This is some-

¹⁹ Paul Kecskemeti, "Totalitarian Communications as a Means of Control," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, vol. 14, no. 2 (Summer 1950); Alex Inkeles and Raymond A. Bauer, *The Soviet Citizen* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1959), p. 175.

²⁰ Cf. James N. Rosenau, "Foreign Policy as an Issue Area," in James N. Rosenau (ed.), *Domestic Sources of Foreign Policy* (New York: Free Press, 1967), pp. 11-50.

¹⁸ William O. Chittick, *State Department, Press, and Pressure Groups* (New York: Wiley-Interscience, 1970).

times interpreted to mean that officials should be responsive to the wishes of the public; sometimes it is seen as meaning that officials should advance the public interest according to their best judgment but are subject to removal if the voters conclude that they have performed poorly. Either interpretation assumes that communications from the public to the government are important, in the former case because they provide guidelines for policy and in the latter because they let officials know whether or not their policies are receiving public acceptance.

Most officials concerned with foreign policy acknowledge that public opinion is important and that they should keep themselves informed about it. As a United States Foreign Service officer has observed, a diplomat cannot limit himself to searching for solutions that will satisfy his own government; he must also find formulas that will satisfy the public back home or that it can be persuaded to support.²¹ Bernard Cohen, who interviewed 50 State Department officials during the year 1965–1966, reported that in their public statements and informal conversations they paid such great attention to the “need for public support” that it began “to look like one of the pillars on which the whole structure of public decision making rests. . . .”²²

The importance attached to public opinion is attested by the many ways that foreign offices attempt to follow its trends. The most common and probably the most important method of monitoring public opinion is to read the press, and this is one reason why officials place such emphasis on keeping up with a variety of news sources and why foreign offices usually publish some kind of domestic press summary for distribution to personnel at home and overseas. Whether the news media do, in fact, give an adequate picture of public opinion is beside the point. They constitute the principal channel through which communications from the public are received.²³ Some gov-

ernments, especially in Western Europe, sponsor public opinion polls on controversial issues, including foreign policy questions. One European government, engaged in a negotiation in which its position was opposed by almost the entire domestic press, conducted its own polls at two-week intervals in order to chart public reaction to the ongoing conversations. Its conclusion was that the press did not in this case give an accurate picture of public opinion.²⁴

The Department of State commissioned surveys of American opinion on foreign policy issues from the end of World War II until 1957, when they were discontinued as a result of Congressional disapproval. Of course, the Gallup, Harris, and other published polls are likely to come to the attention of State Department officials, especially when they deal with foreign policy issues. And there are many other channels from the public to the government. One is the Postal Service, which brings several hundred thousand letters on foreign policy issues to the State Department each year. Visits to the Department by representatives of special interest groups are another source. Advisers from business, universities, and other institutions are invited to come to Washington and consult on a wide range of questions. Even more important are constituent-inspired letters and telephone calls from Congressmen. State Department personnel are encouraged to speak before citizens' groups in order to tap their opinions as well as to provide information. Similarly, American diplomatic personnel are brought back to the United States on home leave, usually once every three years, in part so that they will not get out of touch with the thinking back home.

Even authoritarian and totalitarian states at-

ternal public.” Some of those with whom he talked were “very explicit about the press as a central vehicle in their understanding of public opinion.” *Ibid.*, p. 107.

²⁴ This information comes from interviews conducted by the author. National identifications have been omitted, since respondents were assured that the information they provided would not be used in such a way as to possibly embarrass their governments. In general, polls sponsored by a government within its own country seem to be a sensitive subject. Probably for this reason, no information about the frequency of other government-sponsored polls in Western Europe was obtained; but it was often mentioned that they occurred.

²¹ Glen H. Fisher, *Public Diplomacy and the Behavioral Sciences*, p. 4.

²² Bernard C. Cohen, *The Public's Impact on Foreign Policy* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1973), p. 139.

²³ Bernard C. Cohen observes with respect to the State Department that “the press is the leading point of contact between State Department officials and the ex-

tempt to monitor domestic opinion, although less is known about the details of this process. In Nazi Germany one division of the Reich Security Office conducted a kind of observational opinion poll. It recruited a large number of confidential agents, each of whom was instructed to listen "in his own circle of friends, family, and business associates as well as in streetcars, stores, barber-shops, at newsstands . . . and other public places." From the reports of these agents composite pictures of opinion on such questions as the invasion of Russia, the fall of France, and Allied bombing were compiled.²⁵ It would seem reasonable to assume that similar methods are being used in other states where freedom of expression is not permitted.

In Communist countries, major newspapers have ordinarily encouraged letters to the editor and have also enrolled large numbers of amateur correspondents. There were said to be more than 5 million such volunteer correspondents in the Soviet Union as of the 1960s and major Soviet newspapers were receiving hundreds of thousands of letters annually.²⁶ Only a tiny fraction of the reports and letters are ever published, and it is impossible to know how many of them deal with foreign policy issues. But some of them probably do. If so, they provide insight into public opinion on these issues. In addition, it is likely that information about public opinion at the grass roots comes to the attention of high officials through the organizational channels of the Communist Party, the trade unions, and other mass organizations. Quite a few public opinion polls are conducted in the Soviet Union and Eastern Europe, but as far as is known these do not concern foreign policy questions, at least not directly.²⁷

²⁵ Arthur L. Smith, Jr., "Life in Wartime Germany: Colonel Ohlendorf's Opinion Service," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, vol. 36, no. 1 (Spring 1972).

²⁶ Mark W. Hopkins, *Mass Media in the Soviet Union* (New York: Pegasus, 1970), pp. 296 ff.

²⁷ For a discussion of polls in the Soviet Union, see *ibid.*, pp. 314-334; also Ellen Mickiewicz, "Policy Applications of Public Opinion Research in the Soviet Union," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, vol. 36, no. 4 (Winter 1972-73). Polls conducted in Eastern European countries, exclusive of the Soviet Union, are monitored by the Audience and Public Opinion Research Department of Radio Free Europe. See, for example, "Economic Ex-

It is clear that officials in both totalitarian and democratic states pay attention to opinions of domestic publics on foreign policy issues, but the effect of this attention on resulting policies is not clear. One can assume that in totalitarian states opinions that do not support the government position are stamped out, either by sanctions against those holding them or by campaigns of persuasion. Similarly, it is probable that persuasive campaigns, involving the mass media as well as face-to-face communications, are undertaken when there is reason to believe that the public is ignorant or apathetic with regard to a foreign policy that the government believes should have mass support.

In the United States and presumably in other democracies, more weight is given to the opinions of well-informed and powerful groups than to public opinion at large. An office director in the State Department who was interviewed by Bernard Cohen remarked, "We talk about public opinion, but in our area of the State Department we are concerned with a few individual Congressmen."²⁸ Similarly, in a study of the peace settlement with Japan following World War II, Cohen found that West Coast fishing interests exercised substantial influence.²⁹ And when the Eisenhower administration decided to make a concerted effort to enlist support for its foreign aid program, it focused its efforts on a group of 1,371 "opinion makers," who were invited to attend a conference on the subject in Washington.³⁰

If public attitudes toward a policy that is advocated or being pursued by a government are unfavorable, the most common reaction of officials is to try to change the opinion—not to change the policy.³¹ Indeed, some officials would

expectations in Czechoslovakia" (Munich: Radio Free Europe, mimeo., December 1973). This report compares a poll taken by a Czech newspaper with the findings of Radio Free Europe researchers.

²⁸ Cohen, *The Public's Impact on Foreign Policy*, p. 114.

²⁹ Bernard C. Cohen, *The Political Process and Foreign Policy: The Making of the Japanese Peace Settlement* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1957).

³⁰ James N. Rosenau, *National Leadership and Foreign Policy* (Princeton, N.J.): Princeton University Press, 1963), p. 59.

³¹ Cohen, *The Public's Impact on Foreign Policy*, pp. 166 ff.

regard it as improper to modify a policy that they feel is "right" because it is opposed either by the general public or by interest groups. The only valid reason for policy change, in this view, is that new information about the situation has become available or that a better policy has been worked out. As a former Defense Department adviser put it, "the problem of the government official is to resist the pressures of opinion while giving due weight to the objective facts and logical arguments advanced in support of such pressures."³² And the most usual method of resisting these pressures and changing opinion is to provide more information, issue more press releases, make more speeches, and hold more conferences with influential individuals and groups.

National leaders frequently pursue foreign policies that are opposed by a majority of the domestic public. Prior to 1941 President Roosevelt moved cautiously but steadily to align the United States with the Western European powers, even though polls showed that the American public as a whole wanted the country to stay out of the war. President de Gaulle was much more blunt in his opposition to the integration of Western Europe at a time when nearly three-quarters of French adults said they favored it. Prime Minister Heath led Great Britain into the European Common Market even without majority support among the British public. All three leaders presumably believed that their domestic publics would eventually recognize the correctness of these policies and would give them the necessary degree of support.

Nevertheless, one can also find instances where public opinion appears to have had a substantial impact on foreign policy. Popular opposition in the United States to both the Korean and Vietnam wars seems almost certainly to have influenced the American course of action in both cases. And it is difficult to believe that the officials who pay such close attention to communications from the public are not influenced by them, even though they may not be conscious of this influence on their thinking. As Bernard Cohen observes, "a policy making system which has

mastered all the modes of resistance to outside opinions nevertheless seems, from a long-run perspective, to accommodate to it."³³ One problem, from the standpoint of the student of foreign policy, is that there is no way of measuring the influence of communications from the public on the thinking of officials who take part in the formulation of foreign policy. Yet one cannot conclude that something does not exist simply because it cannot be measured or observed directly.

Another reason why it is difficult to assess the impact of public opinion on policy making is that foreign policy officials are likely to be more concerned with future public attitudes than with opinions that are expressed while a decision is being publicly debated. A leader is ill advised to adopt a policy, even with overwhelming popular support, if he anticipates that the results of this policy will eventually bring down public wrath on his head. Conversely, he is well advised to adhere to an unpopular policy if he is convinced that future developments will justify his decision in the eyes of his compatriots. Perhaps the most important effect of communications from citizens to their government is to give the latter a basis for estimating future public reactions.

It may be that the opinions of publics—whether specialized or general—have little impact on policies that have already been announced but are an essential component that goes into the thinking of policy makers when they attempt to devise strategies for advancing the national interest in future situations. If this is true, communications from the public are not likely to be given great weight by the official who has finally made up his own mind, since he may feel that he has already taken public opinion into account.

PROPAGANDA

Communicating with publics, as well as governments, in other countries has increasingly been recognized as one of the functions of diplomacy. Former Secretary of State Dean Rusk has stated:

³² Adam Yarmolinsky, "Confessions of a Non-user," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, vol. 27, no. 4 (Winter 1963), p. 544.

³³ Cohen, *The Public's Impact on Foreign Policy*, p. 205.

"Today, we in the State Department consider the information program as an indispensable dimension of American diplomacy. Our information activities demonstrate our respect for the opinions of people as well as their governments."³⁴ Students of international relations have identified an area that they call "public diplomacy," which is defined as "the ways in which both government and private individuals and groups influence directly or indirectly those public attitudes and opinions which bear directly on another government's foreign policy decisions."³⁵ Public diplomacy combines the skills of the traditional diplomat with those of the specialist in mass communication and the social researcher. The diplomat formulates the ideas that he would like to have communicated to a foreign public, the social researcher studies the intended audience, and the communication specialist chooses the most appropriate media and composes the messages.

Communications from a government to populations of other countries are carried by media under government control—for example, the Voice of America—or they move through commercial news channels. All methods of communication are used, including short-wave radio, television, motion picture films, publications of many types, news releases, and personal conversations between diplomats and citizens of the country where they are stationed. In 1974 the United States Information Agency spent 209 million dollars on its overseas information activities. At the same time, it estimated the annual expenditures of West Germany, France, and the Soviet Union for similar activities as 351 million dollars, 487 million dollars, and 900 million dollars, respectively.³⁶ The agency's staff, as of 1974, totaled 9,516 persons, and of course this figure did not include diplomats on the payroll of the

State Department or personnel on the staffs of other departments who were engaging in the dissemination of information to other countries.³⁷

Even very small nations maintain foreign information programs, although these may consist mainly of a few hours of short-wave broadcasts per week and the assignment of information personnel to their diplomatic missions. As of 1967, 65 of the 116 countries represented by diplomatic missions in Washington included officials whose titles indicated that they were principally concerned with the dissemination of information.³⁸ These officials were designated as press attachés, press counselors, or information officers. In other embassies the information function was a responsibility of officials with neutral titles, such as second secretary or vice consul. Ambassadors and other officials whose functions are primarily political also engage in communicating with the publics of the countries where they are stationed by making speeches and holding press conferences.

What, specifically, are the purposes of propaganda activities that serve as an adjunct or as an integral part of diplomacy? These naturally differ from country to country and from time to time, but they always are designed so as to advance the foreign policy of the nation conducting them. They may be directed toward creating a favorable atmosphere in which relations between states may be conducted, they may seek to improve the public image of a particular country, or they may attempt to promote or to combat a particular policy.

Efforts to create and maintain a cordial atmosphere involve a wide range of communications. It is important that officials observe politeness and respect in their public references to other powers and their leaders, and that official media do likewise.³⁹ Any disrespectful utterance is likely to attract wide attention and may hamper a specific negotiation or diplomatic relations in general. Thus, toward the end of World War II,

³⁴ Quoted in Robert W. Akers, "An Indispensable Diplomacy," in John Lee (ed.), *The Diplomatic Persuaders* (New York: Wiley, 1968), p. 3.

³⁵ Robert F. Delany, "Introduction," in Arthur S. Hoffman (ed.), *International Communication and the New Diplomacy* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1968), p. 3.

³⁶ The figures for the United States are not directly comparable with those for the other countries, since not all American overseas information and cultural programs are budgeted by the United States Information Agency.

³⁷ *USIA World*, vol. 7, no. 8 (April 1974).

³⁸ Akers, "An Indispensable Diplomacy," p. 3.

³⁹ B. S. Murtry, *Propaganda and World Public Order* (New Haven, Conn.: Yale University Press, 1968), p. 226. Murtry notes, however, that sometimes the advantages of *not* observing cordiality and respect may outweigh the advantages to be derived from it.

when the Voice of America quoted from a column in an American newspaper that included a reference to Italy's "moronic little king," this led to a flurry of publicity, and it was feared that the contemptuous reference would interfere with negotiations leading to the surrender of Italian armed forces. The inability of the United States government to control references to other powers made by prominent persons outside the government (and sometimes even within it) has often caused diplomatic complications. President Nasser of Egypt, for instance, repeatedly expressed irritation at the treatment he received in the American press.⁴⁰ Diplomats and information personnel concerned with foreign policy try to smooth over such irritations when they arise, and also try to promote a positive atmosphere by emphasizing cordiality and respect in the statements over which they have control.

Mass communication helps to maintain an amicable atmosphere when it conveys the message that the culture and achievements of one country are admired in another. If an American institution or group organizes an exhibit of the work of a famous artist from another country, it is likely that the Voice of America will broadcast news of this back to his homeland. And prominent visitors to China and the Soviet Union are likely to find highly favorable articles about themselves in the official press.⁴¹

Diplomats and information personnel also attempt to improve the image of their own country in other parts of the world. This does not necessarily mean that they try to present an idealized picture. Often they are content if the picture is no worse than reality. As an official of the Venezuelan Embassy in Washington stated, "cultural attaches and information directors of Washington embassies devote their working hours to correcting misconceptions and misunderstandings about their countries."⁴² They do this by issuing

information materials—illustrated booklets, mimeographed releases, films, and so on—and also by maintaining cordial relations with the local press. Their hope is that the journalists they cultivate will be willing to carry more positive accounts of their countries, will balance unfavorable materials with favorable ones, and will check information with them when in doubt about its accuracy. American information personnel abroad do much the same thing. Of course, the question of what is a "correct" image of a particular country is a matter for individual interpretation, and it should not be surprising that some officials view their homelands through rose-colored glasses and would like others to do the same.

When it comes to explaining individual policies to foreign publics, the lead is necessarily taken by high officials of the nation concerned. A head of state or a foreign minister may hold a press conference or may give a formal address. Or an official document may be released. It then becomes the task of diplomats and information personnel to ensure that the explanation reaches those who, in their opinion, should know about it. They may also have to interpret the policy for individual audiences. As a former American Assistant Secretary of State has observed, "The government's information program can help enormously in attaching the meaning that we want accepted to a particular action or policy decision."⁴³ Indeed, much of the content of political commentary carried on government-operated short-wave radio is devoted to explanations of individual policies. The explanation is likely to highlight the virtues of a policy if it is one espoused by one's own government, but may be critical of the policy if it is advanced by a government believed to be unfriendly.

A diplomat will frequently appeal to the public of a foreign country over the head of its government, using the normal channels of the international press rather than an official medium such as the Voice of America. Former Secretary of State Dulles, for example, stated that he had spoken of an "agonizing reappraisal" of United

⁴⁰ C. L. Sulzberger, *The Last of the Giants* (New York: Macmillan, 1970), p. 459. Also Robert Murphy, *Diplomat among Warriors* (Garden City, N.Y.: Doubleday, 1964), p. 415.

⁴¹ W. Phillips Davison, *International Political Communication* (New York: Praeger, 1965), p. 204.

⁴² Francisco J. Lara, "The Fight against Misunderstanding," in John Lee (ed.), *The Diplomatic Persuaders* (New York: Wiley, 1968), p. 31.

⁴³ Howland Sargeant, "Communications to Open and Closed Societies," in Arthur S. Hoffman (ed.), *International Communication and the New Diplomacy* (Bloomington: University of Indiana Press, 1968), p. 170.

States foreign policy in the event that France declined to cooperate in a European Defense Community in order to "give French public opinion a jolt." He felt that the French public was not aware of the very grave consequences that might ensue from the policies its government appeared to be considering.⁴⁴

In spite of the effort and resources that governments devote to communicating with foreign publics, it is difficult to determine whether these communications accomplish what is expected of them. If attitudes in one country become more favorable toward another country, is this because of the latter's foreign information program, or is it due to some other factor? If the people in country X become better informed about the foreign policies of country Y, will they necessarily approve of these policies? And even if they do approve of the policies about which they have been informed, will this affect the actions of their own government? As a former British diplomat has observed, "all information work is to some extent an act of faith; it is impossible to prove that it affects anything. . . ."⁴⁵

Nevertheless, it would be even more difficult to prove that communications from a government to a foreign public had no effect on international relations, and common sense and the subjective impressions of large numbers of diplomatic personnel suggest that they do. Research studies, usually commissioned by national information agencies, support these impressions in many instances, although I have never seen one that proved them conclusively. And if one considers national objectives that are less political in nature—for instance, promoting tourism or encouraging trade and investment—then international information can indeed be an effective tool.⁴⁶

⁴⁴ Anthony Eden, *Full Circle* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 1960), pp. 63–64.

⁴⁵ Busk, *The Craft of Diplomacy*, p. 85.

⁴⁶ In point of fact, national governments seem to be devoting more and more effort in their information programs to these relatively nonpolitical objectives. At the end of 1969, 450 active registrations of bodies distributing propaganda in the United States on behalf of foreign principals were on file with the Department of Justice. Most of this propaganda concerned trade, investment, or tourism. "Report of the Attorney General to the Congress of the United States on the Administration of the Foreign Agents Registration Act of 1938, as

Furthermore, in an age when disputes between major powers are likely to arouse anxiety throughout the world community,⁴⁷ attentive publics in all countries expect to be informed about the policies of other governments. Any nation that closed down its international information program completely would be inviting suspicion and resentment, even though many members of the world public might welcome a little less propaganda.

INTERNATIONAL PUBLIC OPINION

Citizens in one or more countries frequently use communications in order to influence the policies of a government in another country. Sometimes these efforts appear to be successful; more often it is impossible to determine whether they have had any effect or not. A recent example is the attempt of groups in the United States and other Western countries to persuade the Soviet government to allow Soviet Jews to emigrate. The concerned groups have communicated with Moscow through petitions, demonstrations at Soviet diplomatic missions, letters to newspapers, messages conveyed by high-ranking visitors to the Soviet capital, and other means. They have also urged their own governments to make representations to the Soviet government. It seems likely that these communications have had some effect on Soviet policy, but to prove this is another matter.

There are numerous cases where the power of international public opinion is alleged to have been demonstrated. A writer in a trade journal for American newspapers, for instance, has maintained that pressure of world public opinion played a role in the downfall of the Argentine government that expropriated *La Prensa* of Buenos Aires early in the 1950s: "The press of the U.S. and of the world became aroused and Peron was subjected to what was probably the brightest spotlight of publicity in the world's press ever given to a usurper of freedom. There is no doubt that world public opinion . . . had much

amended, for the Calendar Year 1969" (Washington, mimeo., n.d.).

⁴⁷ Arthur Lall, *Modern International Negotiation: Principles and Practice* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1966), p. 1.

to do with the dictator's downfall.⁴⁸ More recently, Soviet writer Alexander Solzhenitsyn cited pressure from international literary circles as one reason why he had not received worse treatment at the hands of Soviet authorities: "During my dangerous weeks of exclusion from the Writers Union, the wall of defense advanced by the world's prominent writers protected me from worse persecutions. . . ."⁴⁹ One could mention many other such instances, including cases where international public opinion was brought to bear on the United States and other Western governments. Nevertheless, in nearly all cases it is difficult to determine the degree to which the policy of a government was influenced or whether it was influenced at all.

It is true that foreign policy personnel occasionally mention public opinion in other countries as having entered into their calculations. My interviews with diplomats in European Common Market countries turned up a few references of this type. But in these instances, as in regard to the influence of domestic public opinion, one may ask whether obeisance to public opinion is made because it is a respected component of democratic theory or because it actually played a significant role. And respectful references to public opinion can be balanced by those that are strongly negative. Former Secretary of State John Foster Dulles has been quoted as saying, "If I so much as took into account what people in other countries are thinking or feeling, I would be derelict in my duty as Secretary of State."⁵⁰ Yet Dulles obviously *did* take public opinion into account, otherwise he would scarcely have attempted to "give French public opinion a jolt" in his remarks about "agonizing reappraisal." The observations of those diplomats who *do* ascribe influence to communications from foreign publics and of those who do not are equally difficult to interpret.

Regardless of the extent to which public opinion abroad enters into foreign policy making, diplomats typically give close attention to it.

⁴⁸ Robert U. Brown, "Shop Talk at Thirty," *Editor and Publisher*, Feb. 9, 1974.

⁴⁹ From excerpts of Solzhenitsyn's Nobel Prize lecture published in the *New York Times*, August 25, 1972.

⁵⁰ Lloyd A. Free, "Public Opinion Research," in Arthur S. Hoffman (ed.), *International Communication and the New Diplomacy* (Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1968), p. 51.

Even before World War I, embassies were sending information about public opinion in the countries where they were stationed back to their foreign offices. An examination of the "Kautsky Collection," a compilation of German Foreign Office documents relating to the outbreak of the war, found that about 20 percent of 879 documents examined contained some reference to public opinion. And to support these analyses, German ambassadors directed a constant flow of press clippings and evaluations back to the Foreign Office in Berlin. Many of these were read and annotated by the Kaiser himself. The importance attached to press opinion is illustrated by telegrams such as the following to the German Chargé d'Affaires in Bucharest: "Kindly report continuously, if need be by telegraph, on the attitude of the press there toward the conflict. . . ."⁵¹

The press continues to provide the basis for most evaluations of foreign opinion that are made by diplomatic personnel. This is one reason they devote so much time to reading it, and why editorials and other expressions of opinion are featured so prominently in summaries and digests of media content that are prepared by foreign offices. As a former British diplomat notes in relation to the appointment of his country's first regular press attachés in 1927, "It was their duty to advise the Ambassador on public opinion in the countries concerned, particularly as reflected in the press, and to keep in touch with both local and visiting journalists."⁵²

But public opinion polls are playing an increasing role. These, together with the mass media, often provide the content of opinion summaries prepared by embassies in those countries where polls are taken and published. In addition, governments may commission polls that are designed to illuminate opinions on questions in which they are particularly interested. It is not known how many governments do this or how frequently, but I have run across references to surveys commissioned in the United States by at least a dozen foreign governments.

The U.S. Information Agency sponsors polls

⁵¹ Richard R. Fagen, "Some Assessments and Uses of Public Opinion in Diplomacy," *Public Opinion Quarterly*, vol. 24, no. 3 (Fall 1960), pp. 449-450.

⁵² Busk, *The Craft of Diplomacy*, p. 84.

in nearly all countries where polling is possible. For instance, in March and April of 1972 surveys were carried out in 15 countries around the world to assess the impact of President Nixon's visit to China, to measure foreign sentiment in regard to his projected trip to Moscow, and to tap more general attitudes toward the United States. Other recent polls have been on such subjects as French opinion regarding energy problems, expectations in various countries about assistance from the United States, and the audience for the Voice of America in Nigeria. Multiple copies of the reports presenting the results of these surveys are sent to the Department of State and sometimes to other departments, but there is no way of knowing how much attention they are given.

Supplementing press analyses and poll results are the impressions that diplomats obtain from talking with citizens of the country in which they are stationed, the observations they make on trips throughout the host country, and the insights they gain from conversations with knowledgeable observers—for example, students, researchers, and journalists. Such impressions often appear to carry greater weight with diplomats than more systematic modes of gauging public opinion.

SUMMARY

Four general propositions serve to summarize the preceding analysis and to point the way to further research that can usefully be undertaken:

[1] Skills in using and interpreting public communications are becoming increasingly necessary for government officials concerned with foreign policy. A large part of their time and energy is likely to be consumed by involvement in the five types of communication flows that have been described.

[2] The mass media, and especially elite newspapers, play a strikingly large role in the conduct of diplomacy. Much of the information on which foreign policy personnel base their decisions comes to them through mass media channels. The press is the principal source for information about domestic and foreign public opinion, as well as an extremely important source for information about other governments and events in general.

[3] Public opinion—foreign and domestic—enters into foreign policy decisions, but we do not know just how it enters in or the extent of its influence. More sophisticated methods of studying ways that public opinion affects diplomatic decision making are needed.

[4] Regardless of the extent to which public opinion actually influences foreign policy, it is widely believed to do so. Thus governments expend substantial resources on communicating with publics in other countries in the hope that these publics will influence the policies of their own governments. At the same time, individuals and interest groups use communications in attempts to influence the policies of both their own and foreign governments.